a second look. It felt to me like Victoria and I had the place to ourselves. We drove back to London and I dropped her home at her mum and dad's. Finally it had been like a proper date: dinner for two, even if we had ended up about seventy miles north of where we'd been planning to go.

Next time out was lovely, too: the back row at the movies down in Chelsea. We saw Tom Cruise in *Jerry Maguire*, but all I cared about was whose hand I was holding. The big deal that evening was going back to Victoria's parents' house afterwards and meeting Tony and Jackie for the first time. We walked in and I was so embarrassed. I remember sitting down on the settee, a big brown leather thing, the material gathered and pinned down with those little buttons, worrying about what noise I might make if I moved on it to get comfortable.

Victoria's mum came down and introduced herself. When you first meet Jackie, she can seem a little prickly. Or, at least, that's what it felt like that evening. It was probably as much to do with me, jumping to a new boyfriend's conclusion and imagining that the mother was being a bit sharp with me even though she wasn't meaning to be:

'You're the soccer player then, are you?'

Victoria's mum and dad weren't interested in soccer, but living in Goff's Oak, an area where many players live too, meant they knew some socially. After the opener from Jackie, it was Tony's turn:

'What team do you play for?'

For whatever reason, I don't think they liked the idea of their daughter going out with a soccer player. Maybe I got stuck with someone else's reputation at first, at least until we met and they could judge for themselves. I don't know if they thought soccer players were all loud and cocky but I just sat there on their sofa and was too nervous to say more than a couple of words. At least they didn't kick me out of the house and, after a while, they said goodnight and disappeared upstairs. I'm sure every mum and dad feels that no boyfriend is ever good enough for their little girl. That, as well as me being a soccer player, might have had something to do with Tony and Jackie being wary of me at first. They knew Victoria, though, and that meant they were willing to get to know me. I'm glad they were. When you marry a woman, you become part of her family too. However frosty I might have imagined they were that first night, Tony and Jackie have welcomed me in ever since.